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Gary Smulyan

Baritone saxophonist Gary Smulyan was born on April 4, 1956 in Bethpage, New York. His first big band work with Woody Herman was followed by stints with the Mel Lewis Orchestra, the Phillip Morris Superband and the Vanguard Jazz Orchestra. He has shared the stage and studio with Nick Brignola, Joe Lovano and Benny Green, and currently records as a leader on Criss Cross Records.

Gary was interviewed in Utica, New York on October 17, 2010 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe off-camera, for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, and I'm very happy to have Gary Smulyan here. And I want to start out asking about all those stickers on your baritone sax case.

GS: What do you want to know?

MR: Well, to people who aren't that familiar with the life of a musician, it looks very exotic.

GS: Really. That's interesting.

MR: Yeah. I mean I think it looks like, oh, you've been to all these places, that must be the greatest thing.

GS: Well you know the thing is, I think musicians hear that a lot. They'd say, oh, you're a musician, you must lead a real amazing life, you get to go to all these places. But in many cases that's not really the reality. The reality is you go to a lot of places but you see very little of those places because you go from the airport to the hotel to the sound check, to the concert, and back to the hotel and to the airport the next day. So unless, on rare occasions where we're in a place for a week playing a club, or for a couple of days where we get a chance to actually take a walk and get out of the hotel and see something, a lot of times we're just on the plane and, you know, especially, and you're playing a lot of one-nighters and you're just kind of hoofin' it from place to place. So basically if I get a backstage pass or a sticker I just slap it on my case. So that's — I mean I started doing that a long time ago and I just kind of continued.

MR: Well it looks good.

GS: But that is the reality of musicians on the road is that a lot of times you go to these amazingly cool places and it's all New Jersey.

MR: It's all New Jersey. I like that. It reminds me of that often-quoted Phil Woods story about part of the jazz education should be getting on a bus and —

GS: Yeah. Driving around the campus and that's a lot of it. A lot of it is just — the traveling is — I mean I think we get paid to travel. You know the playing part is incidental. I mean you know sometimes we'll travel for hours and hours to get to a place and then play for

two hours, or not even two hours, sometimes we play a 75 minute set, and just get back on the plane and come home the next day.

MR: Well I noticed something today that I liked and I thought was interesting, and that I should tell our readers and viewers that I just saw you perform in Utica, with a typical sort of assembled group, you know, a quartet that had never performed together before. But you guys had a couple of music stands, which doesn't always happen. Was that your doing?

GS: Uh, well I think for me I like to get into a situation and not necessarily just winging it and calling tunes, I like to bring some arrangements and try and do something, you know, present something with a little more formality and something that's less just thrown together haphazardly, even though I do enjoy that situation as well, um just winging it and getting on the stage and figuring out what you're going to play. We did have the luxury of a short rehearsal and, like I was telling the folks who came out to The Other Side, at the gig this afternoon, is that, you know, jazz is a language and it's like any other language. And if you learn to speak the language you can play with almost anybody. So you know the level of musicianship is high in this area. I mean there's people that can really play. The only thing I was missing, unfortunately, was a bass, because either through budgetary constraints or, I don't know what the reason was, you know the pianist was —

MR: The bass player.

GS: Was playing bass as well as piano. Just in terms from a sound point of view, you don't really get the bottom in the band that you would if you had a bass player playing. That's, for me, something's really missing without the bass.

MR: That's interesting you say that, because I could tell that sound, in the general sense of the word, seems to be very important to you. Because when someone asked you about the biggest difference between playing alto and moving to baritone was all about the sound.

GS: Um hum. Well to me in music, general sound is first. Sound comes before anything. I mean if you listen to all the great musicians in this music, they all have individual sounds. That's the first thing that you hear that grabs you, right? If you listen to, just the tenor saxophone, right? John Coltrane, Johnny Griffin, Gene Ammons, Joe Lovano, Joshua Redman, Chris Potter, Don Byas, Frank Wess, and the list goes on and on, Ben Webster, Coleman Hawkins, Georgie Auld, they all play the tenor saxophone but they all have — Al Cohn, Zoot Sims — I could go on all day — Tina Brooks, Hank Mobley. You know they play one note and you know who they are immediately. And to me that's like the defining thing about being a musician, and for me the most important thing is your sound. And I've given a lot of thought and a lot of practice to try to really develop a sound that's personal and unique to me, because that's the first thing that people hear. I mean you

could be a great technician but if you don't have a good sound no one's going to want to hear you and you're not going to be able to get past your sound. And it's really the identifying characteristic of who you are as a musician. And your sound is not in the instrument, the sound is not — in my case — it's not in the saxophone, it's not in the reed, it's not in the mouthpiece and it's not in the ligature. The sound is something that you carry within your very being. And that's what comes out. So take someone like Sonny Rollins, right? I think that if you gave Sonny Rollins 50 different tenor saxes, 50 different reeds and 50 different ligatures, he's going to sound like Sonny Rollins, with some variation because maybe the instruments aren't comfortable. Maybe his comfort level behind the instrument isn't the same. But essentially what's going to come out is Sonny Rollins. Because his sound is not in the instrument. And I tell that to my students. I say don't look for the magic instrument, because there's no magic instrument.

MR: Right.

GS: Or the magic mouthpiece. Or the magic reed. It doesn't exist. Find what it is that's comfortable, and then practice.

MR: Something that basically works, and then you've got to put your —

GS: You have to put your — it's up to the musician to breathe the life into the music and breathe his life, your breath and your life force into that instrument.

MR: How does jazz pedagogy help or hinder that process?

GS: Well you know I think that there is not as much emphasis placed on that because I think musicians are more concerned with learning harmony and how to play changes and learning tunes, and you know, that's a tricky question. But it should be all part of the same thing. I mean your sound, and developing a sound, is — that should be number one in jazz pedagogy, as far as I'm concerned.

MR: Partly the reason I asked that question is because a lot of the — a number of the really veteran guys whom I've spoken to — sort of bemoaned the fact that the younger players, as they describe them, all sound the same. That they have learned the scales and the patterns and that you can't recognize who they are.

GS: There's a very homogenous way of teaching music in jazz education, in a lot of instances. That's why I think it's really important to get musicians like the older musicians involved in jazz education, because their — the things that are important to them are different than maybe the typical jazz education route of someone who goes to school, gets a bachelor's, gets a master's, gets a Ph.D. and goes right to teaching, without having had the benefit of even spending a lot of time on the bandstand. Because you know jazz is really an experiential music and you have to play with people who are better than you. You have to get your butt kicked on the bandstand. That's an important part of growth as a musician. But you know jazz education has kind of done a little flip flop where you know people

like Yusef Lateef and Max Roach, they were hired at U Mass, I don't know if you — I don't think Max Roach has a Ph.D. in jazz education, but you know these days it's almost like you have to get an advanced degree to even be considered for a jazz teaching position. And I think that's been a change in the last couple of years, that's kind of been the direction that it's been going in. And I think there has to be some kind of a balance between that and getting people who are actually on the scene and touring and playing and, you know, getting them involved as well.

MR: Yeah. Is that your situation?

GS: Which?

MR: I mean you do a lot of educational work?

GS: I do a lot of education but I don't have any full time teaching position. I'm presently the adjunct processor of jazz saxophone at Amherst College. And I have a handful of students every semester. But for me, I really love jazz ed — I love jazz teaching and being in that world. I had a lot of incredible mentors when I was a teenager growing up. I had — when I was growing up on Long Island there was an alto saxophone-clarinet-flute player named Joe Dixon who was a — he played with Bunny Berrigan and Artie Shaw, and you know, he was very active in the swing era, and he had a jazz ensemble of teenagers in Nassau County on Long Island called the Nassau County Youth and Euphonic Jazz Orchestra. And he became a really strong mentor. And when I grew up there were some amazing saxophone players on Long Island: Billy Mitchell was from Detroit, he played with Thad Jones, he was really a powerful force, and I had a chance to play with him a lot and get my butt kicked from him as well. So that's — it's important for young musicians to have that experience, and because of the demise of touring big bands, you know the apprenticeship system is kind of disappearing. So young musicians coming out of college are forced to kind of really create their own situation and create their own scene.

MR: That's also interesting, that almost every junior high and high school in the country has a jazz band now, a swing band. But not that many of these students actually listen to the music.

GS: Yeah, that's a problem. And the music is not easy to find in a lot of cases. It's still very much an underground music in the sense that it's not prevalent on television, it's not easy to find on the radio unless it's a college station that has jazz programming, it's not mainstream in our society. So unless you have a band teacher who really is into the music and brings in records and exposes the students to the music, it just becomes just another ensemble for them to play the music without really even understanding the language and how it's really meant to be played. But the fact that those ensembles exist is really a great sign and the fact that there is support from the administration and support from the

community to keep those ensembles going, I think that's huge. Because the kids need some kind of exposure and the younger the better.

MR: Before we leave this sound question, what are the actual — I mean you said this great thing just a while ago about the mouthpieces and the reed and you actually answered my question before I asked it. What else actually goes into this sound question. I mean when you say you can identify any number of people from one phrase, what makes that happen? Why does Ben Webster jump off the record as Ben Webster or Coltrane?

GS: Well I just think that during that time period I think there was a real emphasis on kind of finding your own way and finding your own path, and developing your own sound. You have to also realize that these musicians existed before there was — you know jazz education was even an apple in somebody's eye. I mean they had the opportunity to develop musicianship on the bandstand when they were out playing, probably from a very young age. You know, you'd play in local bands and then Ben and others may have joined Duke's band, and so I think they were forced to do that. And they didn't have all the books and records and play-a-long records and all that. I just think that the scene was different and that was really kind of a value characteristic in your playing was to find your own way, you know, find your own sound. You know music has a very — the development of jazz is a very organic development from one generation to the next. And within that generation musicians have had very personal or unique approaches or sounds. I think it's what's valued. And I think we need to kind of go back to that kind of, you know the mentality of that and the importance placed on that. So you know what? Find your way. You know you have all of these books and all of these aids but is it really helping you in the long run to kind of find who you are and discover who you are as a musician? And for me it's also, it's not just music that goes into creating the sound, it's like how you live, what kind of books you read, what kind of movies you watch, what kind of people you hang out with. I mean that all has a big effect on how you play.

MR: So in some sense it's almost comical to tell a 19-year-old kid you've got to find your own sound man. I mean they're not grown up yet. I guess they can start on it.

GS: Yeah, but no one's going to find their own sound when they're 19 or 20. It's very unusual. Because like you said, they're incredibly young. But I think that they have to be encouraged to start that process at a young age, if they're going to really go on and consider playing this music for their life, for their work, for their passion. Because it has to be a passion. It's not a job.

MR: Go on about that, it's not a job.

GS: You can't — I don't consider what I do as having a job. You know being a musician is inherently wrapped up in who I am as a human being and I can't separate those two things, between being a musician and being alive on this planet as a human being. And I

mean there's a lot of passion there, and I feel like a lot of times I feel like if I couldn't play that I would die. I just feel it's just so much a part of my existence in the world, and I try to instill that in young musicians, like this has to be something that you absolutely have to do, and it's almost like if you have a choice you should do something else in a way. Because it's not an easy life, being a musician. There's a lot of sacrifices involved. I mean just the amount of time that you have to practice, that's just a small one. I mean if you start making it and becoming successful then you're away from home. If you have a family you don't see your kids grow up. You know it's not necessarily always an easy existence.

MR: And for instance you said you're leaving for Japan on Tuesday. And how long will you be gone?

GS: About ten days.

MR: So you have to constantly juggle your on-the-road commitments with whatever you have at home, including your employment at home, your teaching, but also your family life and that whole end of things.

GS: Well my teaching, at least that situation now, as long as I make the number of lessons that I have to get in by the end of the semester I can do that. Like I said I'm not full time. I think full time faculty — people who have full time teaching positions, the demands made on them are a lot more, in terms of going to meetings, and so I don't have those demands on me. I have the freedom to come and go, which is kind of a nice balance. But you know, yeah, I was away a lot. I have a son who is 22 and a daughter who is 19, and I missed a lot of things in their life. I missed a lot of experiences. I remember many times going straight from the airport to my son's baseball game with my suitcase and my baritone. You know? Trying to catch the tail end of his game. And I think that was hard for him. I think it was hard for my kids to be away that much. I mean they told me — my family's always supported me, they've always understood that this is what daddy does, or this is what my husband does, and I see how the very core of the existence as a musician enabled me to be really great and supportive in terms of my coming and going, but I think, I'm sure as a matter of fact, that it hasn't always been easy. In fact there was — when we moved into our first house, my wife and I, in Hastings-on-Hudson, New York in Westchester County, we were living in another town and we bought a house and the day we moved I had to go on the road. So we moved the last box in the house and then the car service taxi came and I went to the airport and I left town and she unpacked every box. And there was another time where — these kind of things happened a lot — when we moved to our first apartment in Brooklyn we moved the last box in and the phone rang and it was Count Basie's band who wanted to know if I wanted to go on the road. This was when Thad Jones was conducting. They called me to go on the road for eight weeks.

And I didn't go. I said, "No, we just moved in, I can't, I couldn't do this." But I'm a little regretful about that because it would have been the only time that I would have had a chance to have Thad stand in front and play with him conducting. But it just didn't feel right. And so another time there was a band called the Philip Morris Superband, which was conducted by Gene Harris, this was going to do three world tours, '89, '90 and '91. And it was an amazing band. It was Ray Brown and Jeff Hamilton played the first year on drums, and James Moody and Herb Ellis and Urbie Green and Johnny Coles and Sweets Edison and Jerry Dodgion. I mean it was an amazing band. And we went on the road for three months. And in '89, so my son was two. Yeah, he was two years old. And I came back three months later and he cried when he saw me, because he didn't know who I was. He thought, he didn't recognize me. And that was like, wow. That's really, talk about a knife in the heart, you know that was a deep moment. So you know this, like everything in life, it's a juggling act and it's trying to achieve some kind of a balance and trying to achieve some kind of serenity in your life, you know, between work and being home. But I imagine that there are other jobs that require long hours and I would imagine if you were like a high powered attorney or a surgeon or a businessman where you're on the road. I mean it's not just musicians who have to deal with this, it's like people in all kinds of professions. I mean I'm sure there are people who work 16, 17 hours a day who don't see their families, and they never leave their — I mean they just go to work and come home. They still don't see their kids. So, not that it's a justification, but it's a reality that one's work requires time and if I hit the lottery I could stay home a lot more.

MR: If you hit the lottery. If you did — what would be a dream project for you?

GS: Wow. A dream project. You know I don't think I have to win the lottery to do a dream project. To be honest with you, I think I'm really incredibly blessed and really pleased with all the projects I've been able to do at this point. You don't necessarily need a lot of money to make great music. So I'm not sure. See I've done all my records in one day in six hours. So if you were to give me four or five days in the studio I don't know what I would do. I like the pressure of being able to create a moment. Give me a jazz record as the moment.

MR: I mean think of all the great, thousands of great records that have been done in those kind of situations, two four-hour sessions.

GS: Exactly. And people standing around one mic and just playing. Well I don't know. It seems like an excessive amount of time to put a jazz record together. For me, it's like I said, to kind of put something together in six hours and to try to get a moment or capture a moment in time with warts on it — it's not going to be perfect — I mean there's no perfect jazz record, no perfect jazz solo. I mean there are some more perfect than others of course. But when I did my record with strings, we did that record in four hours

because there was an issue with the studio with the mixing board, so we lost two hours of time — with recording time. So we did that record in four hours, and every take was a first take, and no listen-backs. We didn't listen to anything. And so Bob Belden, he arranged the music and conducted, and it was really, I mean he held it together and he made that session happen. I mean that was a pressure day. But you know, like I said, if you have great musicians and you can kind of pull it together then you can do these kind of things. So I don't know. I'm very fortunate to be very happy with most of the recordings I've done, and for all the musicians I've been able to play with.

MR: This passion you have for music, is there is precedent for it in your parents or your grandparents or anything? Where'd it come from?

GS: My mom was a dancer, a ballet dancer. She had a dancing school, a dance academy on Long Island. My father is not, you know, they're not musicians. And we wonder about that. I mean I really don't know where that came from. It was just, I don't know. I guess it's a blessing and a curse. Well I really don't know because there haven't been any musicians in my family. The closest thing I can come to is my mom's dancing.

MR: So there's some artistic genes going on.

GS: Oh yeah. Yeah and I think my folks had a record player and there was music, you know, music in the house. But in terms of jazz, you know, really nothing. And to be honest with you I'm not really sure I would have found jazz if I didn't hear Fats Waller when I was 13.

MR: That was an AHA moment.

GS: It was a really amazing moment for me. I was just flipping the radio dial and heard Fats Waller playing "African Ripples," which is a solo piano piece, and I'd never heard anything like that. I was completely knocked out. I was like what is this music and who is this piano player? And it was, that was a real life-defining moment, it really was. And it was a total accident. I was just listening to the radio and I just happened to come upon this and it was a jazz show called "Just Jazz" on WRBR, that was hosted by an absolutely amazing disc jockey named Ed Beach who was a real, I mean he was really responsible for a lot of my listening education in terms of when I was younger. He would focus on one artist for five nights, every night. So you'd hear five nights of Fats Navarro, then the next night you'd hear five nights of Charlie Christian — I mean the next week not the next night — then he'd do five nights of Johnny Griffin. Five nights of Wynton Kelly. And the list went on and on and on. And it was really something to hear this, to be exposed to this music in that way. So I was riveted to the radio. So that was a big part of my kind of formative years, learning about this music. But I'm not sure that any of it would have happened if I didn't hear that piece.

MR: Has he ever heard that story?

GS: Yeah I told him.

MR: Did you? That's great.

GS: Uh huh, I did tell him. And we actually corresponded, so I have some letters from him and he was a real teacher, I mean he really was great.

MR: The radio — that's not the first story I've heard. I've heard really nice variations on your story, people, including myself, that it came through the radio, this like wow, what is that?

GS: Yeah, no, and I still love the radio. I listen to Phil Schaap every morning. I mean I've been listening to "Bird Flight" for I mean I don't even know how many years, probably thirty years. I listen to him every morning. And so he and Phil Schaap and Ed Beach are kind of, you know, they're on the same plane in terms of, you know, the disc jockey as teacher, the disc jockey is informing, not just playing the music but they look upon what they do as teaching. So it's very cool. And so the radio is a really powerful medium. But you have to find it. It's not out there. You have to find it. So you have to have some curiosity. And that's another thing that I try to instill in my students is that, you know, you have to be curious. You have to look for things. I mean I remember when I was a kid I used to spend every Saturday at the record store. I would spend my whole day. I'd save up my money and go to the record store. We had record stores back, with LPs, you know, those flat discs that are made out of plas — you know, anyway, I used to spend hours, and you know then I would buy records. I'd would say hey, wow, who's this saxophone player? I don't know who this is. And you know when I grew up we were all curious about this music. So I try to instill that in my students. I say you have to be curious, and you have to really try and find it. And now with YouTube and all these on-line sources, I mean the whole history of this music, you can see it. You can see Coleman Hawkins play. You can see Lockjaw Davis play. You can see all these guys play. Benny Carter. I mean we didn't have that growing up when I was a kid. So to be able to — oh man, that's like the most beautiful thing, to just turn out your computer and watch all these amazing musicians play. That's really special.

MR: Let me ask you about, I think what was a sort of important milestone in your career with Woody Herman. Do you recall the phone call? Who called you about being on that band?

GS: It was Bill Byrne who was the trumpet. He was the band manager. And he called — well let me preface the story, I was playing on Long Island with, well it was called the Long Island Jazz Quintet at this time. This was 1978. And it was Glen Drews who was playing trumpet, actually he's the one that got called to play with Woody first. So Glen Drews the trumpet player, he left our group and he was on Woody's band. And a couple of months later the phone rang and it was Bill Byrne, who was the road manager and the fifth trumpet player. Glen Drews had recommended me to join the band. So that's how they

kind of found out about me first. And they asked me if I wanted to join first of all, and I mean that was kind of why I was playing in the first place, trying to get a gig like that, to go out and play. So they were on the road 50 weeks a year. They played all the time, and all kinds of really amazingly interesting places. One day he played an Elks Club for a dance, and the next night he'd be at Carnegie Hall. The next day he'd play like at a VFW, the next night he'd play in a high school auditorium in a gym, and the next night he'd play in a symphony hall in Chicago, the next night he'd play at a jazz festival, the next night he'd play — you know it was like really an eye opening experience in terms of what it's like to be a musician. Because you have to be a jack of all trades. You have to play for all kinds of people in all kinds of different places, and still play at that level. Woody Herman was like, wow, I can't even begin to speak about what an influence he was, just in terms of how you have to be well rounded and how you have to act and behave as a musician on the bandstand. It was a really amazing lesson. So as I say I got the call and I'd never played baritone. This is when I switched to baritone. So I went out and bought a baritone, a Yamaha baritone with a low A and two weeks later after I got the call, it was May 25, 1978, I joined the band in Bridgeport, Connecticut. I took my horn out of the case and I was so nervous. Because first of all Woody's — one of his biggest pet peeves was alto saxophone players who play baritone. I found this out later. He hated that. And that was describing me to a tee. And you know this was the first time I was ever going to play the baritone in public. So I took the baritone out of the case and sat down next to Joe Lovano. He was in the chair next to me. And so but that was it. It was like "Four Brothers" boom. Early on, here we go. And it was a great band. Mark Johnson was playing bass and he was, at that time, auditioning for the job of Bill Evans, which he got. John Riley was playing drums who now is playing in the Vanguard Jazz Orchestra sitting in Mel Lewis' seat, Frank Tiberi of course, Dave LaLama, Ralph's brother on piano. It was really an incredible band. And the other thing that struck me about Woody that was really inspiring was how forward thinking he was. He didn't live in the past at all. I mean he was into all kinds of modern music. He had commissioned Chic Corea to write a three movement suite for the band that we actually played a lot, and he loved the music of Steeley Dan, we did a Steeley Dan record called "Aja." So he was not somebody who was just content to just play his big hits from the past. He really had one foot in the past and certainly one foot in the future. So he was — and what a talent scout. I mean look at all the people who went through that band, from the forties all the way up until he passed. I mean it's a veritable who's who of music. So just being able to be on the bandstand with him really was an honor and a privilege, and I still feel blessed to have had that opportunity because it's also — that's when I became a baritone player, those two years, then I really loved the baritone. And he didn't fire me. So he must have

seen some germ of something there, some potential. I didn't play the alto anymore after that.

MR: What would have got you fired from the Woody Herman band? Not you in particular, but did he have —

GS: Yeah, if you didn't fit in with the way — if you didn't fit in — if he didn't like your sound, if you didn't fit in with what he was kind of hearing in the ensemble, he didn't fire a lot of people. He fired a couple. I think it was really just based on does this musician kind of fit in with my concept of this band. And the way you knew you were fired is if when you were playing Woody looked at Bill Byrne and went like this — or went like this —. That was you're fired.

MR: And then Bill would break the news to you.

GS: Yup.

MR: Wow. And was it —

GS: And I was waiting for this, the first two weeks.

MR: That's funny. But they'd have to give you a two week notice or something like that.

GS: Yeah. But I mean it didn't happen too often.

MR: Okay. Do you remember what you made?

GS: Yeah. 350 dollars a week, this was 1978, and we had to pay our own rooms. So it was 15 dollars a night for a hotel. But we got around that by something called ghosting, where one guy would check in to the hotel and four guys would stay in the room. So we would spend 15 divided by 4, what like 3 bucks apiece in the hotel, and really — so like four guys would get off the bus and then they'd drive the bus around to the back of the hotel and sixteen guys would get out and we would get a room with two beds and then we would flip a coin to see who would sleep on the box springs. So we'd put the mattress on the floor and you'd flip a coin and whoever lost had to sleep on the box spring. See this is what I'm talking about. The music is so romantic and exotic isn't it? So I slept on my share of box springs, believe me.

MR: That's really interesting. I had heard other terms but not that one in particular. I mean we did it when I was — in the rock & roll days we did similar stuff, but that's really great. And I chuckled today because, I forget what the question was at the concert, and you mentioned a tune, you were talking about playing gigs to put food on the table.

GS: Sure.

MR: And you mentioned the tune "Cherry Pink and Apple Blossom White" and I played that song last night.

GS: You did?

MR: Sure. That's funny. You do what's required.

GS: Well you know I think that colleges, as part of jazz education should teach these young musicians how to play a gig like that. I think that would be really valuable. Because you get out of school and I mean I used to do four or five — you know we'd call them club dates. Some people call them casuals. I think it depends on what part of the country you come from. But it's a wedding or a bar mitzvah basically. And you know sometimes I would do five of those on a weekend. You know, two on Friday, two on Saturday — no one on Friday, two on Saturday and two on Sunday. And that's hard. Because they're four hour gigs and if you play a cocktail hour that's a five hour gig. So that, and plus you have to drive. You have to drive from one gig to the other, set up, play, and you know most of the music is pretty horrendous. I mean this is when disco was around, so we'd play a lot of disco tunes. But I was doing — I mean I was playing with Kenny Warner, Billy Drews, I mean we used to have like a horn section with five horns. And a full rhythm section and a bunch of singers. And we would have these big full-blown productions. That would cost a lot of money for the families. But at least we were all together playing music with our friends. And it's not so easy, just from a mental standpoint, to have to play "Hava Nagila" five times on a weekend, and that's just one hora. We used to play medlies of horas. You know, play a half hour hora medley. But you have to know the tunes.

MR: Spell hora.

GS: H-O-R-A. No not whore. No hora. It's a particular form of Jewish dance, that you play at Jewish weddings or bar mitzvahs. Anyway, so we used to play tons of these things. So do you want to at least have the instrument in your mouth when you're playing? Or do you want to work at a diner flipping burgers or being a waiter? You know I think it would be a good idea to teach, I mean granted I haven't done a club date in many, many, many years, so I don't know if people still do them or if now there's DJs. So I don't even know if people have live music at a dance anymore. The way the music business is going, Broadway and shows, it could be, who knows? It could be that whole scene where having a live band at a wedding or a bar mitzvah could be finished. I really don't know, I'm not involved in that world anymore.

MR: Yeah. The DJs get most of it but there are still some out there.

GS: But that was really part of one's education as well, because you're forced to learn a lot of tunes — a lot of tunes and a lot of different styles.

MR: It's good ear training.

GS: It's good ear training and it's just good character building. It's not all — being a musician is not necessarily about being creative all the time, it's also about the nuts and bolts of going to work.

MR: Well said. Let me run a few names by you. In addition to Fats Waller, Cannonball Adderley.

GS: Wow. What can you say about Cannonball Adderley? Cannonball Adderley was huge and I don't mean in a physical sense, I mean a huge part of my development growing up. I mean when I was playing the alto saxophone he, Charlie Parker, Phil Woods and Gene Quill, they were I mean huge influences. Wow. Just Cannonball's sound and his time and his phrasing and his articulation and just, you know, how funky he was. It was, wow, what can one say about Cannonball Adderley.

MR: It makes me think of — I mean I thought of him because you were talking about sound. And to me, his personality just like came out through his instrument. And it's a good example of what you were talking about.

GS: It's actually a perfect example of you play how you are. And you can't hide. You can't be different than you play. Your playing is a direct reflection of who you are as a person. And I tell my students, I say what comes in comes out. If nothing comes in, nothing is going to come out. So like I was saying before, the movies you watch, the books you read, everything that comes in, as a musician, is going to come out in your breath. It's important. I mean Cannonball was a school teacher, right? So he was constantly talking to kids and preaching, and so he played like that.

MR: Here's some names I'll lump together, which probably I shouldn't, but guys like Pharoh Sanders, Patrick Gilmore —

GS: John Gilmore.

MR: John Gilmore, thank you. Albert Ayler. Did those people have any impact on you?

GS: I was listening to them when I was younger. I had a childhood friend named Peter Schmidt who's father was the original French horn player in the New York Brass Quintet and I went to high school with him. And his brother Fred was a big avante garde jazz fan. And so when I would go over to his house and hang out and play and talk and I mean just whatever kids do, his brother would have Sun Ra, he'd have Albert Ayler and Charles Tyler, and all these complete free music going on. So I was exposed to that when I was younger. I wouldn't say it was very influential in my approach, but I definitely was exposed to it and I was open and I was interested in hearing about that music. So I was listening to like Charlie Christian and Benny Goodman and then Albert Ayler at the same time. And it's funny because I kind of started on the opposite ends of the music, like from swing music and then I'd listen to Louis Armstrong's Hot Fives and Hot Sevens, and then listening to Sun Ra and Albert Ayler and I kind of moved in this way and wound up with Charlie Parker. So I came at it this way. But I definitely did hear a lot of that music growing up.

MR: Okay.

GS: But I'm coming more from a bebop, post-bop tradition. I like playing songs. I like playing on forms, I like complex chord changes. I likes tunes with hard chords, and I'm really into harmony.

MR: I could tell that, I think, when I heard you play, I forget what song it was but you did this really cool sequence and both of them ended on this really weak, I think it was the flat nine or something, but I could tell that this was not an accident, that this was the way you play.

GS: It's deliberate. It's not planned, but I'm really fascinated with harmony and I spend a lot of time at the piano and I think all of the solo transcribing I did when I was younger has really been instrumental in helping me develop that kind of harmonic sense. I think it's important for musicians to have that. It's almost like they have to know what they're doing. You know jazz is a lot more than just playing by ear or by feeling. There's this misconception [beatnik rap, sings] oh I'm a jazz man, I play what I feel man. And that's not what it is. I mean jazz is really, four things have to hook up, right? What you can think, what you can hear, what you can feel and what you can execute on your horn. But the thinking part is really important. Because unless you're really thinking about the music you can't really manipulate the changes, right, if you want to put substitutions in or if you want to kind of play a different key or you want to just kind of use some harmonic devices to kind of accentuate your playing. That requires some thought.

MR: What percentage of — I don't know how to ask this question —

GS: You mean how do you divide those up?

MR: Well I was thinking about one of the really uptempo tunes you were playing, and your solo had a nice arc to it, and sort of about three quarters to the end you got really quick, you were playing really quick. And I'm wondering how many of those notes are deliberate?

GS: They were all deliberate. I knew exactly what I wanted to play. I didn't plan anything out in advance, but at the moment I knew exactly what I wanted to do.

MR: Okay. What do you do if you make a mistake?

GS: Um. I make a lot of mistakes. Right? Jazz is made by human beings. We're flawed. So, you know, fundamentally. So like I said before, there's no perfect solo. So you make a mistake you go again.

MR: Well what constitutes a mistake for you?

GS: Yeah well that's a good question. Playing something that I didn't really want to play. Making a wrong choice. Not ending the way I want it to end. I think for me the most important part of your solo is how you end, because that's what people are going to remember. You could play a great solo, but if your ending is weak and you're not

committed in terms of how you want to end, you kind of just peter out or your cadence is not strong, that kind of weakens what came before. To me.

MR: That's a good thought. I wonder if part of that is thinking ahead. Like should I do one more chorus or should I end here?

GS: Well yeah, that's hard, that's a hard choice to make, and there's been many instances where I should have stopped where I kept going. And there's been other instances where I should have kept going and I stopped.

MR: This might be an obvious question, but how do you play different if you have a really cooking rhythm section and if you don't?

GS: Well if you don't have a cooking rhythm section I have to do all the work, and that's hard. And I've been in that situation where I just, you know I just feel like I'm dragging a train by my teeth. You know it's really hard. And after a whole evening of doing that, that's really tough. So but if you're playing with a cooking rhythm section it's effortless, because you're all on the same page. You know you just kind of play and it's easy and it's fun and it's less work, because everybody's working equally as hard to achieve the same thing, to try to create this music. Yeah, that's not easy. And a lot of musicians have always done that. You know they go on the road and just play with local rhythm sections and sometimes you get some good ones and sometimes you don't get some good ones. But you still have to play. I mean I did a tour, I went to Australia quite a number of years ago, and did a gig in this club and this promoter put this rhythm section together, it was like a rock rhythm section, like a bass player, drummer, and piano player. And they just didn't know any tunes and it was bad. It was really, really, really tough.

MR: How many blues can we play?

GS: Well I wish we could have played one. It wasn't even that. They didn't like playing that.

MR: You mean the old one-chord vamp?

GS: It was tough. That was a hard night. And I remember reading an interview with Sonny Stitt when I was younger, because he really didn't have the luxury of touring with his own band. He would just go from club to club to club to play. And that was hard for him.

MR: Yeah. That probably attributed to some of the problems that these guys — you know, being in a club and then it's like a drag night after night after night with different people. It's not a healthy lifestyle.

GS: Yeah. There are a lot of distractions out there. Well because it is exhausting.

MR: I know you have to get to another gig soon. Any immediate future plans or long term goals for you?

GS: I just want to keep practicing and getting deeper inside this music. It's funny you know, I'm 54 years old and I feel very committed to getting out there more as a leader. I've, up until this point, been a sideman in many different bands. And I really want to get out and

start playing quartet and trio and getting out and getting more gigs under my own name so I can emerge as a leader on this instrument. Because there aren't that many people who are dedicated to just playing the baritone saxophone. And I think in a way you get typecast as a big band player, as a baritone player, I think it's hard to break out of that, but I'm determined to try and give it my best shot. But as much as I enjoy playing in big bands I enjoy playing in small groups that much more, and so I'm trying to create more opportunities to do that at this point. So that's something that I feel really strongly about. If you really look at the history of the baritone, there's really been only one musician and that's Gerry Mulligan, who's been able to really make it as a leader.

MR: And a big part of that was his writing, right?

GS: Yeah. And it was also right place right time. And it was also being a good salesman. That's not to take away from his genius. He was certainly an incredible musician and I can only aspire to be a tenth of the musician that he was, he was really of course very important. But for me, I've always thought that Pepper Adams was a more interesting baritone player as such. At least he touched me in a more meaningful way in terms of what I was trying to do on the instrument, and he never really emerged as a leader in terms of being able to tour with his own band. So that's something that I'm really striving towards at this time is to try and achieve some kind of direction where I emerge as a leader on this instrument. There hasn't been one in a long time.

MR: In some time. I read a small thing about — that you enjoy playing with just drums and bass.

GS: I do. I love playing — that's my chosen environment. I had the great pleasure of recording with Christian McBride and Billy Drummond and we did a trio record called "Hidden Treasures." And the freedom in that, without a piano or without a guitar is, for me, just magic. Because I just feel free to kind of go and take the music in any direction, where I can kind of go where I want without being kind of locked in with chords. And that's hard work too, because it's hard to stop, it's like kind of you have to play all night. But that's okay, I really like that. Ideally that's the group that I would like to go out and play with. But it's challenging for the audience. I think it's hard to get club owners to book that, because first of all to get a baritone sax player booked at all it's kind of hard to get past that, and then, without a piano, that's kind of tricky.

MR: Yeah. I suppose you're asking quite a bit from your audience.

GS: It's demanding. But I try to play tunes, or tunes based on standards, you know, so I try to not make it too alienating and try to bring them in in terms of playing tunes or playing material that kind of brings them in. Because the bottom line at the end of the day is that people are coming to hear us play and we're trying to play something that makes them

feel good. Right? And to reach them in some way. So even though you're playing with just bass and drums I think you can still do that.

MR: Well you've had quite a few awards over your years, you've been part of things that got awards, that's pretty cool.

GS: Yeah. I think things are starting to happen for me. I'm very pleased about that.

MR: Well I'm glad to hear it. And I enjoyed hearing you.

GS: Thank you.

MR: And on that note, we'll wrap up and get you to your next gig.

GS: Thanks for the opportunity.

MR: All right.

GS: It was a pleasure. I hope that was okay.